

Not all cardio is created equal

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Sep 07, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/xBAk65pUCLo> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter rates five popular cardio exercises based on joint impact, calorie burn, muscle retention, and versatility — cycling and the stair master earn perfect 10s; running scores lowest.

Contents

-  Running
-  Stair Master
-  Rowing Machine
-  Jump Rope
-  Cycling

Running 0:00

- **Rating: 5/10**
- Primary knock: hard on joints due to high-impact movement
 - Makes it unsuitable for certain populations
 - Specifically calls out overweight clients and older individuals as people he cannot have running

Stair Master 0:00

- **Rating: 10/10** — Carter calls it "the escalator machine" and is emphatic about its quality
- Low impact on joints
- Builds leg muscles to a meaningful degree
- Burns a tremendous amount of calories in a short amount of time

"If you call it the escalator machine the way I do, it's a 10."

Rowing Machine 0:22

- **Rating: 8/10**
- Low impact on joints
- Can burn a lot of calories

- Docked two points simply because Carter finds it "weird" — no performance-based criticism

Jump Rope 0:22

- **Rating: 9/10**
- Low impact
- Burns a lot of calories
- Great for cardiovascular system
- Highly versatile — can be used for HIIT (high-intensity interval training) cardio

Cycling 0:46

- **Rating: 10/10**
- Burns a lot of calories
- Key differentiator: retains more muscle mass than running
 - Muscle retention is explicitly cited as the reason it earns a perfect score over other options